

Process	Purpose	Typical Parent(s)	Expected Location
System	Windows Kernel	N/A	N/A
Registry	Registry Memory Process	N/A	N/A
smss.exe	Session Manager	System	C:\Windows\System32\smss.exe
csrss.exe	Client/Server Runtime	smss.exe	C:\Windows\System32\csrss.exe
wininit.exe	Windows Initialization	smss.exe	C:\Windows\System32\wininit.exe
winlogon.exe	User Logon	smss.exe	C:\Windows\System32\winlogon.exe
services.exe	Service Control Manager	wininit.exe	C:\Windows\System32\services.exe
lsass.exe	Local Security Authority	wininit.exe	C:\Windows\System32\lsass.exe
lsaiso.exe	Credential Guard	lsass.exe	C:\Windows\System32\lsaiso.exe
fontdrvhost.exe	User Mode Font Driver	wininit.exe (Session 0), winlogon.exe (User Session)	C:\Windows\System32\fontdrvhost.exe
svchost.exe	Windows Services Host	services.exe	C:\Windows\System32\svchost.exe
dllhost.exe	COM Surrogate	svchost.exe, explorer.exe	C:\Windows\System32\dllhost.exe
WmiPrvSE.exe	WMI Provider	svchost.exe	C:\Windows\System32\wbem\WmiPrvSE.exe
taskhostw.exe	Generic Task Host	services.exe, explorer.exe	C:\Windows\System32\taskhostw.exe
audiodg.exe	Audio Engine	svchost.exe (AudioSrv)	C:\Windows\System32\audiodg.exe
spoolsv.exe	Print Spooler	services.exe	C:\Windows\System32\spoolsv.exe
WUDFHost.exe	User Mode Driver Framework	services.exe, svchost.exe	C:\Windows\System32\WUDFHost.exe
TrustedInstaller.exe	Windows Modules Installer	services.exe	C:\Windows\servicing\TrustedInstaller.exe
TiWorker.exe	Windows Update Worker	TrustedInstaller.exe	C:\Windows\WinSxS\...
alg.exe	Application Layer Gateway	services.exe	C:\Windows\System32\alg.exe
SearchIndexer.exe	Windows Search	services.exe	C:\Windows\System32\SearchIndexer.exe
SearchProtocolHost.exe	Search Protocol	SearchIndexer.exe	C:\Windows\System32\SearchProtocolHost.exe
SearchFilterHost.exe	Search Filter	SearchIndexer.exe	C:\Windows\System32\SearchFilterHost.exe
SecurityHealthService.exe	Windows Security	services.exe	C:\Windows\System32\SecurityHealthService.exe
MsMpEng.exe	Microsoft Defender	services.exe	C:\ProgramData\Microsoft\Windows Defender\Platform\...
NisSrv.exe	Defender Network Inspection	MsMpEng.exe	Defender Platform Folder
MoUsoCoreWorker.exe	Windows Update	svchost.exe	C:\Windows\System32\MoUsoCoreWorker.exe
CompatTelRunner.exe	Telemetry	svchost.exe	C:\Windows\System32\CompatTelRunner.exe
DeviceCensus.exe	Device Inventory	svchost.exe	C:\Windows\System32\DeviceCensus.exe
LogonUI.exe	Login Screen	winlogon.exe	C:\Windows\System32\LogonUI.exe
userinit.exe	User Initialization	winlogon.exe	C:\Windows\System32\userinit.exe
explorer.exe	Windows Shell	userinit.exe	C:\Windows\explorer.exe
dwm.exe	Desktop Window Manager	winlogon.exe	C:\Windows\System32\dwm.exe
sihost.exe	Shell Infrastructure	winlogon.exe	C:\Windows\System32\sihost.exe
ctfmon.exe	Text Services	explorer.exe, TabletInputService	C:\Windows\System32\ctfmon.exe
RuntimeBroker.exe	UWP Permission Broker	explorer.exe, ApplicationFrameHost.exe	C:\Windows\System32\RuntimeBroker.exe
ApplicationFrameHost.exe	UWP Window Host	explorer.exe	C:\Windows\System32\ApplicationFrameHost.exe
StartMenuExperienceHost.exe	Start Menu	explorer.exe	C:\Windows\SystemApps\...
ShellExperienceHost.exe	Shell Experience	explorer.exe	C:\Windows\SystemApps\...
SearchHost.exe	Windows Search UI	explorer.exe	C:\Windows\SystemApps\...
SecurityHealthSystray.exe	Defender Tray	explorer.exe	C:\Windows\System32\SecurityHealthSystray.exe
cmd.exe	Command Prompt	explorer.exe, services.exe, task scheduler	C:\Windows\System32\cmd.exe
conhost.exe	Console Host	cmd.exe, powershell.exe, Windows Terminal	C:\Windows\System32\conhost.exe
powershell.exe	Windows PowerShell	explorer.exe, cmd.exe	C:\Windows\System32\WindowsPowerShell\v1.0\powershell.exe
pwsh.exe	PowerShell 7	explorer.exe	C:\Program Files\PowerShell\7\pwsh.exe
rundll32.exe	DLL Launcher	explorer.exe, cmd.exe, svchost.exe	C:\Windows\System32\rundll32.exe
regsvr32.exe	Register DLL	explorer.exe, cmd.exe	C:\Windows\System32\regsvr32.exe
wscript.exe	Windows Script Host (GUI)	explorer.exe, cmd.exe	C:\Windows\System32\wscript.exe

cscript.exe	Windows Script Host (CLI)	explorer.exe, cmd.exe	C:\Windows\System32\cscript.exe
mshta.exe	HTML Application Host	explorer.exe	C:\Windows\System32\mshta.exe
regedit.exe	Registry Editor	explorer.exe	C:\Windows\regedit.exe
mmc.exe	Microsoft Management Console	explorer.exe	C:\Windows\System32\mmc.exe
taskmgr.exe	Task Manager	explorer.exe	C:\Windows\System32\taskmgr.exe
tasklist.exe	Process Listing Utility	cmd.exe	C:\Windows\System32\tasklist.exe
net.exe	Network Administration Tool	cmd.exe	C:\Windows\System32\net.exe
net1.exe	Legacy Net Tool	net.exe	C:\Windows\System32\net1.exe
runas.exe	Run As	explorer.exe, cmd.exe	C:\Windows\System32\runas.exe
mstsc.exe	Remote Desktop Client	explorer.exe	C:\Windows\System32\mstsc.exe
rdpclip.exe	RDP Clipboard	TermService (svchost.exe)	C:\Windows\System32\rdpclip.exe
smartscreen.exe	Defender SmartScreen	explorer.exe, Edge	C:\Windows\System32\smartscreen.exe
utilman.exe	Ease of Access	winlogon.exe	C:\Windows\System32\utilman.exe
osk.exe	On-Screen Keyboard	utilman.exe, explorer.exe	C:\Windows\System32\osk.exe
TabTip.exe	Touch Keyboard	TabletInputService (svchost.exe)	%ProgramFiles%\Common Files\Microsoft Shared\Ink\TabTip.exe
OpenWith.exe	Open With Dialog	DCOM Launcher (svchost.exe)	C:\Windows\System32\OpenWith.exe
DrvInst.exe	Driver Installer	svchost.exe (DeviceInstall)	C:\Windows\System32\drvinst.exe
logoff.exe	Logoff Utility	cmd.exe, explorer.exe	C:\Windows\System32\logoff.exe